

PAST PERFECT: Elgin Talkies still in action



A Reel Time Act

A 110-year-old movie hall fights against time and continues screening films at Rs 20 a ticket

■ **By Stephen David**

Everything about this building is quaint; an image straight from a sepia-toned dog-eared album. Not much has changed at Elgin Talkies, a 110-year-old movie hall on Shivaji Road, Bangalore, besides the people who come to watch classic films.

Named after the second British viceroy to India, Lord Elgin, this brick building was erected in 1896. It was the same year the French Lumiere brothers first demonstrated their motion cinema equipment in New York, London and later in Bombay. For about 30 years it provided a stage for dance and performing arts, graced by the presence of British folk as well as the 'natives' who were thrilled with the shows—also performed in many vernacular languages. The owner, S. Krishnamurthy, 57, says his great-grandfather Veerabhadra Mudaliar who built this hall decided in 1930 to convert the theatre into a movie hall. "Even the projector that he bought then, an American-made Cinerama, has been functioning without major glitches," he says. Other than some days dedicated to its maintenance, the 300-seat hall has been running without pause. He nostalgically recounts the images of visitors arriving in horse-carts in the mid-1960s and '70s.

One can still watch a film here for as little as Rs 20 a ticket,



while multiplexes in the city charge 10 times more. As a worker from Tamil Nadu, Periya Swamy, put it: "This place is good value for our money. We can watch a film and enjoy a nice dinner, all for less than Rs 70. We only hope it isn't demolished for commercial purposes."

Krishnamurthy says the first Indian film *Alam Ara* was also screened here. But due to the high price of procuring the latest movies, it has to now make do with old films to keep its projectors running. It is currently screening old Hindi films—*Khel* and *Loha*, and sometimes screens even regional films like the Tamil *Thimuru*. Since it is economical to run films on a fixed-rent basis, it is rare that one runs for several weeks—an exception being *Yaadon ki Baaraat* which ran for two months in 2006. The hall screened *Laila Majnu* (1954) to mark the platinum jubilee of Indian cinema a few years ago.

Elgin has missed the attention of the heritage buffs. But for supporters like Arun Pai, who are creating an awareness of the old world Bangalore, this is a fit case of a legacy which needs to be showcased worldwide. Krishnamurthy hopes to preserve this building. Government grants can come in handy. For now, he is waiting for "divine intervention". Maybe his prayers will be answered and Elgin Talkies will become a permanent landmark in India's movie history. ■